2.4 $\pi^2/6$

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP III 2018, Question 7

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP Support Programme's question database:

step.maths.org/questions/18-s3-q7

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself If a polynomial $a_n x^n + a_{n-1}x^{n-1} + \cdots + a_0$ has roots $r_1, \ldots, r_n$, what is $r_1 + \cdots + r_n$ in terms of the coefficients?

STAGE 1 De Moivre

Ask yourself Write $\cot\theta + \mathrm{i}$ as a single fraction. What do you notice about the numerator?

STAGE 2 The polynomial

Ask yourself In $(c+\mathrm{i})^N - (c-\mathrm{i})^N$, which terms of the two binomial expansions cancel, and which double?

Pause and try For which θ is the left-hand side zero? Use this to find n different roots of the polynomial.

STAGE 4 The squeeze

Ask yourself Put $\theta = \frac{m\pi}{2n+1}$ and add up over $m = 1, \ldots, n$. What do the two outer sums become? What does the middle sum have to do with $\sum 1/m^2$?

Try this next

1. **The 1992 version.** Try STEP III 1992, Question 8 (step.maths.org/questions/92-s3-q8). It uses a polynomial like the one in this section to find exact sums of squared tangents and cosecants. (*Hint:* if you know a polynomial whose roots are r_i, what polynomial has roots $1/r_i$?)

2. **Odd squares.** Deduce from $\sum 1/m^2 = \pi^2/6$ that $1 + \frac{1}{9} + \frac{1}{25} + \frac{1}{49} + \cdots = \frac{\pi^2}{8}$.

3. **Fourth powers.** HARDER Use $\sum r_i^2 = (\sum r_i)^2 - 2\sum_{i<j} r_i r_j$ and the coefficients of the polynomial to find $\sum_{m=1}^{n} \cot^4(\frac{m\pi}{2n+1})$, and adapt the squeeze to prove $\sum 1/m^4 = \pi^4/90$.

4. **How fast?** Using the lower bound in part (iii), show that $\frac{\pi^2}{6} - \sum_{m=1}^{n} \frac{1}{m^2} < \frac{\pi^2}{4n}$. How large an n does this guarantee is enough for the partial sum to be within 0.001 of $\pi^2/6$? Compare with the true error, which is close to $1/n$.

Further reading

- **William Dunham, *Euler: The Master of Us All*** (Mathematical Association of America). Chapter 3 tells the story of the Basel problem with the mathematics in full.
- **Aigner & Ziegler, *Proofs from THE BOOK***, Chapter 9, "Three times $\pi^2/6$". Includes the proof in this section.
- **Paul Nahin, *Dr. Euler's Fabulous Formula*** (Princeton University Press). Complex numbers, Fourier series and sums like this one.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 2.4:
https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch02/basel.html